

to the enemy position, infantry would charge with bayonets fixed, either putting the defenders to flight or engaging in hand-to-hand combat, often grasping their muskets by the barrel and wielding them like clubs.

Although Civil War operations sometimes approximated this ideal of an infantry attack, mostly they did not. Terrain was against it. European tactics were designed for fighting on open ground; in the swamps and forests of the American wilderness a looser style of fighting was inevitable. Troops were often inadequately disciplined, especially early in the war. The more likely sequence of events in an encounter was that one side would advance and fire, the other side would rush forward from their defensive position to fire, and a general melee ensued. But above all, the traditional European method of infantry attack was in crisis because improvements in artillery and the adoption of the rifle musket had tipped the balance decisively against the attacker.